

bronze-winning side will play the World Cup. It's an experienced side—we have one of the best goalkeepers in P.R. Sreejesh and one of the best dragflickers in Harmanpreet Singh. I always say, dragflickers *chalega toh* team definitely *chalega*. There's also Akashdeep, Mandeep, Lalit leading the attack line and defender Amit Rohidas making a vital contribution as a first rusher. We always fare well at home. With the support of the crowd, I'm hopeful we will play well in Rourkela and Bhubaneswar.

Photographs by **CHANDRADEEP KUMAR**



STICK SKILLS Indian hockey team members Amit Rohidas (right) and Neelam Sanjeeb Xess train at the Birsa Munda Stadium in Rourkela

Odisha hosting the 2018 World Cup. Once Hockey India won the bid to host the World Cup again, Patnaik decided to extend the tournament to Rourkela and thereby acknowledge the region's contribution to hockey. After evaluating the existing SAIL stadium, it was decided that a bigger-capacity venue was needed. The Biju Janata Dal government spent Rs 261 crore to develop the structure. "Naturally, when we do it the second time, we are aware we need to up the game," says Krishna. With the Lok Sabha and assembly elections scheduled next year, many see the developments as Patnaik's way to reach out to the district's tribal populace, which has been the focus of even the BJP, which appointed its former Odisha minister Droupadi Murmu as President of India.

Hockey is not the only sports priority for Odisha. The state also supports the men's water polo team, which trains at the Kalinga sports complex in Bhubaneswar. With a sports budget of Rs 911 crore for 2022-23, Odisha is developing an indoor athletics stadium in Kalinga. "Indian athletes training should not be affected by adverse weather conditions," says Krishna about the initiative. The complex will also see an indoor aquatic centre, a high performance badminton centre where Pullela Gopichand will start an academy and the upgrading of a sports science centre in association with Abhinav Bindra.

For now, though, there will be no escaping hockey in Odisha for two weeks. On a chilly January night, the Indian team trained under floodlights at the Birsa Munda Hockey Stadium, where it begins its World Cup campaign. Captain Harmanpreet Singh and vice captain Rohidas led the drills on the pristine, 'signal-blue' turf. Twenty men warmed up, playing football, skipping and stretching before taking up their sticks. Australian coach Graham Reid could be heard encouraging the boys with periodic shouts of "*chalo, chalo*". Currently ranked sixth in the world, the Indian team is still dominated by players from Punjab, but a growing diversity is evident too—players hail from Manipur, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh and Kerala, in addition to Odisha. Expectations for the team to win its first World Championship title in 46 years—the last being in 1975—are high. Standing in India's way are the formidable Australian side and defending champions Belgium. Sreejesh, who has been trying to pick up some Odia from Rohidas, was upbeat. "It is not easy to perform well in front of 21,000 home supporters, but the goal is how to take that crowd as the 12th man of your team," he says. Truly, tier upon tier of brick-coloured seats of the imposing amphitheatre that is the Birsa Munda Stadium will turn into a heaving mass of supporters intent on spurring the team to success. If India does stand on the podium, we will have Odisha to thank. ■